

Ethical Governance of AI and Organizational Resilience in Healthcare: Reframing Organizational Purpose Under Multipolar Crisis Conditions

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ABSTRACT

This article demonstrates that managerial AI systems play a constitutive role in redefining organizational purpose during crisis. Rather than merely supporting decision-making, AI systems function as sensemaking infrastructures that shape executive interpretations of organizational performance, risk, and stakeholder priorities. Drawing on an integrative review of literature on organizational purpose, AI ethics, healthcare management, and crisis governance, alongside an analysis of European and French regulatory frameworks, the study conceptualizes AI as an ethical and political mediator of stakeholder conflict. The analysis identifies a set of interrelated ethical dynamics: purpose drift toward short-term operational stability, selective visibility of stakeholder claims, normalization of algorithmic arbitration in morally plural contexts, and fragmentation of accountability in crisis governance. This paper draws up a conceptual framework that positions ethical AI governance as a core component of organizational resilience.

Keywords: Organizational purpose, executive sensemaking, stakeholder conflict, AI ethics, organizational resilience

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INTRODUCTION

Healthcare organizations are increasingly facing a structural condition of crisis, rather than episodic disruption. Over the past decade, sanitary emergencies, demographic ageing, chronic workforce shortages, budgetary pressures, regulatory intensification, and accelerated digital transformation have converged to produce environments of sustained organizational stress (Duchek, 2020). Evidence from the COVID-19 pandemic also demonstrates that crises reshape stakeholder expectations around sustainability, trust, and organizational well-being, reinforcing the need for organizations to balance operational resilience with broader societal responsibilities (Chan et al., 2022). These overlapping pressures generate uncertainty not only about operational continuity but also about the legitimacy, priorities, and societal role of healthcare organizations. In such contexts, organizational purpose becomes both more salient and more contested (McGahan, 2023; Henisz, 2023).

Organizational purpose has been widely theorized as a normative compass that guides organizational action beyond narrow performance objectives (Mota & Morrison, 2023). Recent scholarship emphasizes that purpose plays a critical role in enabling organizations to navigate stakeholder pluralism, moral ambiguity, and institutional volatility (McGahan, 2023; Jasinenko & Steuber, 2023). Rather than functioning as a stable mission statement, purpose is increasingly understood as an ongoing process of sensemaking through which executives interpret competing expectations and justify strategic choices (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010; Weick, 1995). This process becomes particularly visible in crisis situations, where trade-offs between efficiency, equity, care quality, employee well-being, and public accountability cannot be deferred (Duchek, 2020; McGahan, 2023).

Within this landscape, artificial intelligence has emerged as a central managerial technology in healthcare organizations. Predictive analytics, optimization algorithms, performance dashboards, and generative systems for reporting and communication are now embedded in routine managerial activities (European Commission, 2019; World Health Organization [WHO], 2021). These systems promise to enhance coordination, anticipate risks, and stabilize operations in the face of uncertainty. As such, AI is frequently framed as a key enabler of organizational resilience (OECD Legal Documents, 2019; WHO, 2021).

However, this instrumental framing obscures the deeper organizational effects of managerial AI. By shaping how problems are defined, which data are rendered salient, and which outcomes are prioritized, AI systems intervene directly in executive sensemaking processes (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010; Weick, 1995). They influence how managers perceive organizational performance, assess risk, and evaluate stakeholder claims. In doing so, managerial AI systems participate in the ongoing construction and enactment of organizational purpose (McGahan, 2023; Henisz, 2023).

This intervention is ethically consequential in healthcare organizations, where managerial decisions indirectly affect access to care, working conditions, and the distribution of risk across patient populations and professional groups (Morley et al., 2020; WHO, 2021). Importantly, these effects are often cumulative and diffuse rather than immediate and visible. As a result, the ethical implications of managerial AI tend to remain under the radar of formal ethical oversight, particularly when systems are classified as "administrative" rather than "clinical" (Char et al., 2018; Morley et al., 2020).

The challenge is further intensified under conditions of multipolar crisis. In such contexts, the margin for deliberation narrows, decision-making accelerates, and reliance on technical systems increases (Duchek, 2020). AI-mediated outputs may come to be perceived as objective necessities rather than contestable judgments, thereby reconfiguring how stakeholder conflicts are arbitrated (Mittelstadt,

2019; Morley et al., 2020). The question is therefore not whether AI supports crisis management, but whose resilience it serves and at what ethical cost (McGahan, 2023; WHO, 2021).

Against this background, this article asks two interrelated questions. First, how does the everyday use of AI in healthcare management reconfigure organizational purpose under conditions of sustained crisis (McGahan, 2023; Henisz, 2023)? Second, how do managerial AI systems shape the governance of stakeholder conflict and organizational resilience (Duchek, 2020; Morley et al., 2020)? By addressing these questions, the article seeks to reposition AI ethics within broader debates on organizational purpose, executive sensemaking, and responsible leadership (Mota & Morrison, 2023; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010).

The article proceeds as follows. The next section reviews relevant literature on organizational purpose, crisis and moral pluralism, AI-mediated sensemaking, and the ethics of AI in healthcare management. The third section outlines the integrative methodological approach adopted. The fourth section presents the core analytical findings, identifying key ethical dynamics through which managerial AI reshapes organizational purpose and resilience. The fifth section discusses the theoretical implications of these dynamics for understanding organizational resilience beyond performance metrics. The final sections develop methodological and managerial implications before concluding.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Organizational Purpose and Moral Pluralism Under Crisis Conditions

The resurgence of interest in organizational purpose reflects a broader reassessment of the role of organizations in society (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023). Purpose is increasingly conceptualized as a guiding principle that articulates why an organization exists and how it creates value for a plurality of stakeholders (Mota & Morrison, 2023). Unlike traditional goal-oriented frameworks, purpose-oriented perspectives emphasize normative commitments and relational responsibilities (Jasinenko & Steuber, 2023; McGahan, 2023).

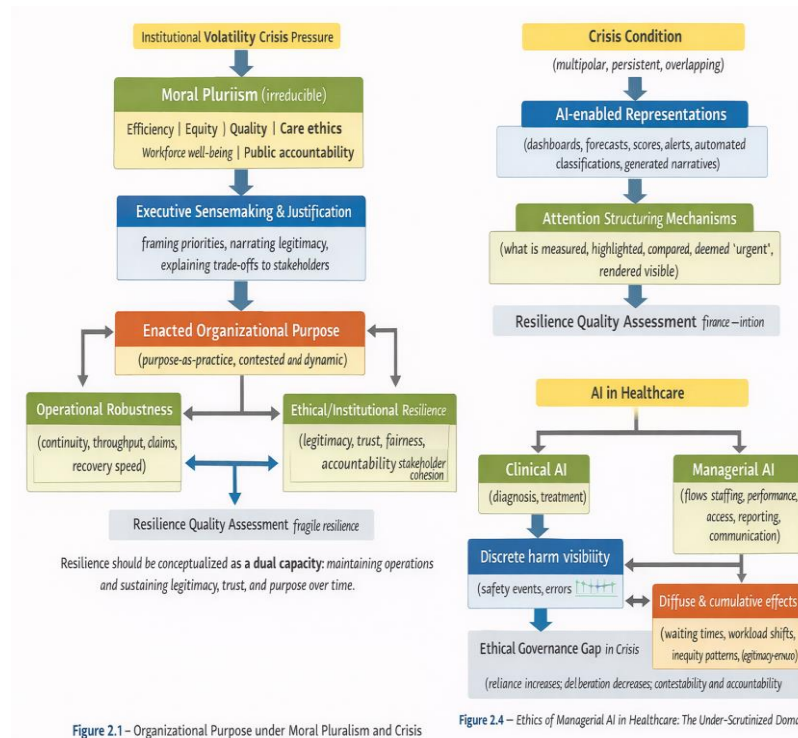
Recent theoretical work highlights that organizational purpose becomes particularly salient in contexts characterized by moral pluralism (McGahan, 2023). Organizations routinely face competing and incommensurable value claims from stakeholders, including shareholders, employees, customers, communities, and regulators. Purpose functions as a mechanism through which these competing claims are interpreted, prioritized, and justified (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023). Importantly, purpose is not a fixed attribute but an evolving construct shaped through executive sensemaking and organizational practices (Mota & Morrison, 2023; Weick, 1995).

Crisis contexts amplify these dynamics. Crises expose the limits of established routines and force organizations to confront trade-offs that are usually managed implicitly (Duchek, 2020; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). In healthcare, crises bring into sharp relief tensions between efficiency and equity, cost containment and care quality, professional autonomy and managerial control (WHO, 2021). Under such conditions, organizational purpose is both mobilized as a source of legitimacy while being contested as stakeholders experience the uneven distribution of burdens and benefits (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023).

Scholars have argued that crisis situations reveal the inherently political nature of organizational purpose. Decisions taken in the name of survival or resilience often privilege certain stakeholder interests while marginalizing others (McGahan, 2023). The legitimacy of these decisions depends not only on outcomes but on the perceived fairness and transparency of the decision-making process

(Henisz, 2023). Purpose thus operates as a moral and rhetorical resource through which organizations seek to justify their actions in volatile environments (Mota & Morrison, 2023; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010).

Figure 1: Organizational Purpose under Moral Pluralism and Crisis



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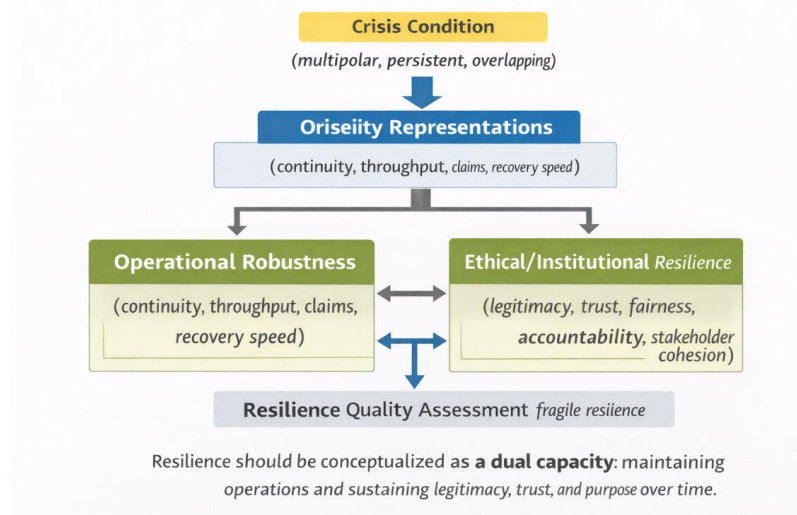
Crisis, Resilience, and the Limits of Performance-Based Conceptions

Organizational resilience is frequently defined as the capacity to absorb shocks, adapt to change, and maintain core functions (Duchek, 2020). In managerial discourse, resilience is often operationalized through indicators of continuity, efficiency, and recovery speed. While such metrics are valuable, they risk narrowing the concept of resilience to technical robustness (Duchek, 2020).

Critical perspectives argue that resilience also has ethical and institutional dimensions. An organization may maintain operations while eroding trust, legitimacy, or stakeholder commitment (Duchek, 2020; Henisz, 2023). In healthcare, resilience that is achieved at the expense of professional well-being or equitable access to care may undermine the organization's long-term capacity to fulfil its public mission (WHO, 2021). Ethical resilience, in this sense, refers to the ability to sustain purpose, legitimacy, and relational integrity under stress (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023).

This distinction is particularly relevant in multipolar crises, where organizations face not a single shock but a succession of overlapping pressures (Duchek, 2020). Under such conditions, short-term adaptations may accumulate into structural transformations that redefine organizational priorities. Understanding resilience therefore requires examining how crisis responses reshape organizational purpose over time (McGahan, 2023; Henisz, 2023).

Figure 2: Crisis-Driven Resilience Trade-Offs - Aligning Robustness with Legitimacy and Trust



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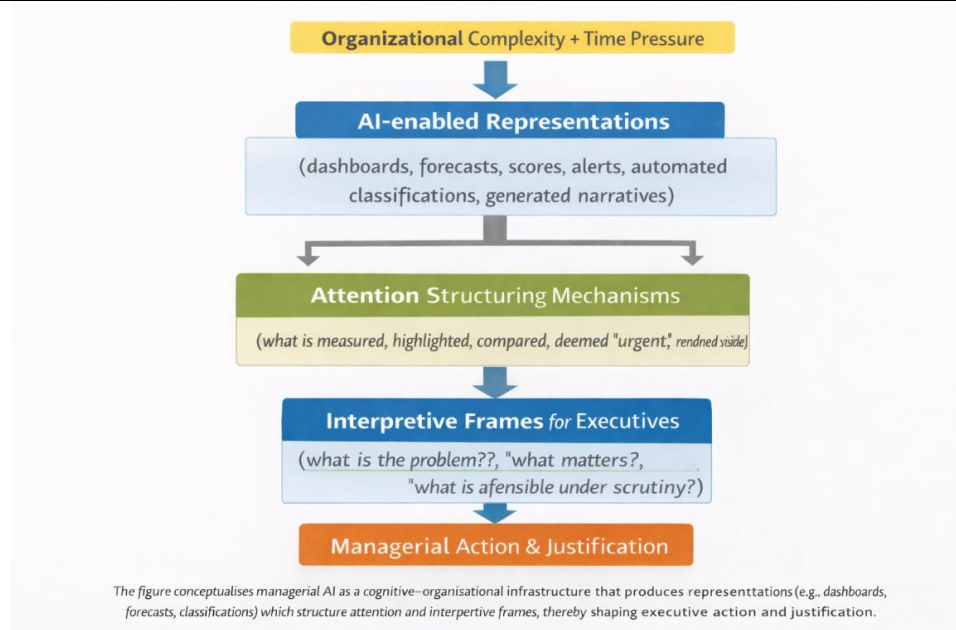
Artificial Intelligence as a Sensemaking Infrastructure

Research on AI in organizations increasingly moves beyond technical performance to examine cognitive and organizational effects (Mittelstadt, 2019). Algorithmic systems structure attention by defining what is measured, predicted, and visualized.

Dashboards, forecasts, and automated classifications influence how managers interpret organizational reality (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). Emerging scholarship further suggests that AI systems are increasingly perceived as socially intelligent actors rather than passive computational tools, making anthropomorphic interpretations an important factor influencing managerial trust, reliance, and decision-making (Borah, 2026). From a sensemaking perspective, AI systems provide frames that guide interpretation and action (Weick, 1995). They reduce complexity by translating heterogeneous phenomena into standardized indicators and scores. While this reduction is necessary for action, it also involves normative choices about what counts as relevant, acceptable, or urgent (Mittelstadt, 2019; Jobin et al., 2019).

In crisis contexts, the sensemaking role of AI becomes particularly influential. Time pressure and uncertainty increase reliance on technical systems perceived as objective and authoritative (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). As a result, AI-mediated representations may acquire a taken-for-granted status, shaping decisions without explicit reflection on underlying assumptions (Mittelstadt, 2019).

Figure 3: Algorithmic Sensemaking Pathway: From Dashboards to Managerial Justification



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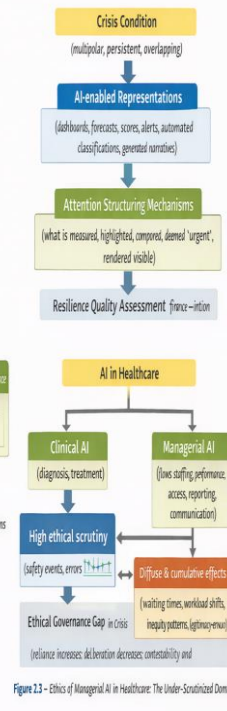
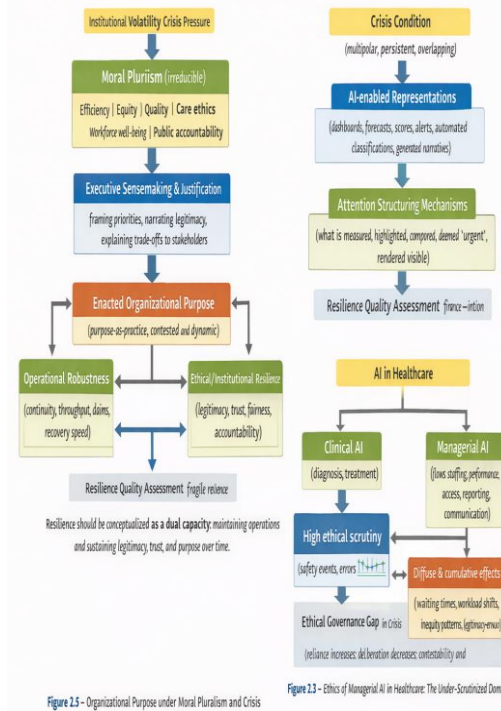
Ethics of AI in Healthcare Management: An Overlooked Domain

The ethics of AI in healthcare has predominantly focused on clinical applications, such as diagnosis, treatment recommendations, and patient monitoring (Char et al., 2018; Morley et al., 2020). This literature identifies well-established concerns, including bias, transparency, accountability, and patient autonomy (Morley et al., 2020; WHO, 2021). However, managerial uses of AI raise distinct ethical issues that remain comparatively underexplored (Morley et al., 2020).

Managerial AI systems influence healthcare outcomes indirectly by shaping resource allocation, workflow organization, and performance evaluation. Their effects are often distributed across populations and over time, making harms less visible and harder to contest (Morley et al., 2020; WHO, 2021). Moreover, because these systems are framed as administrative tools, they often escape the ethical scrutiny applied to clinical technologies (Char et al., 2018; Mittelstadt, 2019).

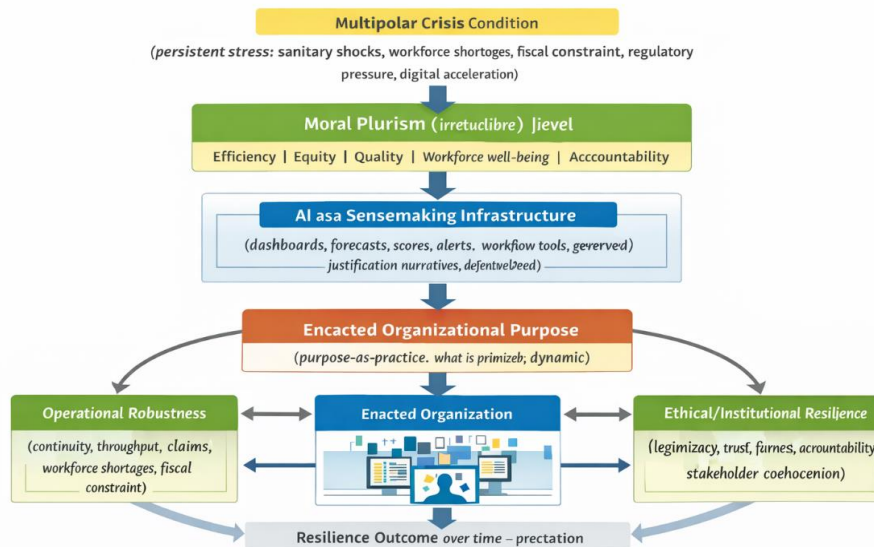
This gap is particularly problematic under crisis conditions, where managerial decisions have amplified consequences and reduced opportunities for deliberation (Duchek, 2020; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). Understanding the ethics of managerial AI therefore requires situating these systems within broader organizational processes of purpose construction, stakeholder governance, and resilience (McGahan, 2023; Henisz, 2023).

Figure 4: Ethics of Managerial AI in Healthcare



Source: Author's own

Figure 5: How AI-Mediated Sensemaking Reconfigures Organizational Purpose



Source: Author's own

Figure 5 synthesizes the core argument of this article by conceptualizing artificial intelligence as a mediating infrastructure through which organizational purpose is enacted under conditions of multipolar crisis. The figure illustrates how persistent crisis pressures intensify moral pluralism and channel executive sensemaking through AI-enabled representations. These representations structure attention and justification, shaping what is prioritized in practice and how stakeholder claims are arbitrated. As organizational purpose is enacted through routine, AI-mediated decisions, stakeholder conflict is reorganized rather than resolved, ultimately influencing whether resilience is reduced to operational robustness or extended to ethical and institutional sustainability. The framework thus

highlights ethical AI governance as a critical determinant of long-term organizational resilience and legitimacy.

METHODOLOGY

Research Design and Epistemological Positioning

This article adopts a conceptual and integrative research design aimed at advancing theory rather than testing predefined hypotheses, an approach well suited to fragmented and emerging domains (Duchek, 2020; Morley et al., 2020). The study is grounded in an interpretive epistemology, which views organizational phenomena as socially constructed through sensemaking processes, discourses, and practices (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010; Weick, 1995).

Rather than treating artificial intelligence as a neutral technological artefact, this analysis conceptualizes managerial AI as sociotechnical infrastructure embedded in organizational routines, power relations, and normative frameworks (Mittelstadt, 2019; Jobin et al., 2019). This positioning allows for an examination of how AI systems participate in the construction of organizational purpose and stakeholder governance, particularly under crisis conditions (McGahan, 2023).

Integrative Literature Review Approach

This study relies on an integrative literature review, a method that enables the synthesis of diverse bodies of knowledge to generate new theoretical insights. This approach is appropriate given the interdisciplinary nature of the research question, which spans organizational theory, business ethics, healthcare management, AI ethics, and crisis studies.

The review integrates four main streams of literature:

- Organizational purpose and executive sensemaking, with particular attention to moral pluralism, stakeholder theory, and legitimacy under conditions of uncertainty.
- Crisis and organizational resilience, focusing on critiques of performance-centric resilience and the role of ethics and legitimacy in sustaining organizations over time.
- Artificial intelligence in organizations, emphasizing the cognitive, interpretive, and governance effects of algorithmic systems rather than purely technical performance.
- Ethics of AI in healthcare, extending beyond clinical applications to include managerial and administrative uses of AI.

Rather than aiming for exhaustive coverage, the review prioritizes conceptual relevance and theoretical influence. Seminal articles, recent high-impact publications, and authoritative institutional reports were selected to capture dominant debates and emerging perspectives.

Crisis-Oriented Analytical Lens

A distinctive feature of this study is its crisis-oriented analytical lens. A crisis is not treated as an exceptional or temporary disruption but as a structural condition shaping contemporary healthcare organizations. This perspective reflects the cumulative nature of the pressures faced by healthcare systems, including recurrent public health emergencies, workforce instability, financial constraints, and continuous digital transformation.

By adopting this lens, the analysis foregrounds how ethical issues related to AI emerge and intensify under conditions of sustained stress. It also allows for the examination of how organizational purpose and stakeholder relations evolve over time as crisis becomes normalized.

Analytical Procedure

The analysis proceeded through a multi-stage interpretive process.

Firstly, cases of managerial AI use in healthcare were identified from the literature and policy documents, including workforce planning, patient flow management, performance monitoring, resource allocation, and organizational communication. These use cases were treated as empirical anchors for conceptual analysis.

Secondly, ethical tensions associated with these use cases were coded inductively, focusing on how AI systems shape decision rationales, stakeholder visibility, and accountability structures.

Finally, these ethical tensions were interpreted through the lens of organizational purpose and resilience. This step involved examining how AI-mediated practices contribute to the redefinition of what healthcare organizations prioritize, justify, and protect under crisis conditions.

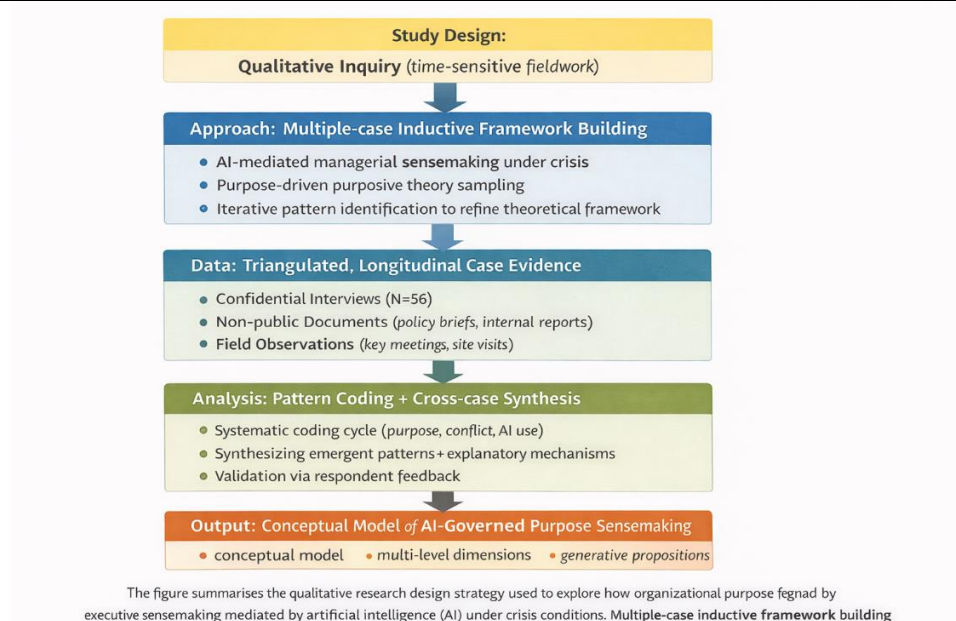
Throughout the process, constant comparison was used to identify recurring patterns and to refine conceptual categories. The outcome of this analysis is a set of core ethical dynamics that illuminate the role of managerial AI in crisis governance.

Scope and Limitations

As a conceptual study, this article does not claim empirical generalizability. Its contribution lies in theoretical integration and conceptual clarification. While the analysis draws on the French and European regulatory context for illustrative purposes, the proposed framework is intended to be analytically transferable to other healthcare systems facing similar crisis dynamics.

The article deliberately focuses on managerial uses of AI rather than clinical applications. This choice reflects the aim of addressing an underexplored domain of AI ethics and does not imply that clinical AI raises fewer ethical concerns.

Figure 6: Integrative Conceptual Analysis of Managerial AI under Multipolar Crisis



Source: Author's own

Figure 6 summarizes the methodological logic underpinning this study. The article adopts an integrative, theory-building design that synthesizes interdisciplinary scholarship on organizational purpose, crisis and resilience, and AI ethics, complemented by structured analysis of the European and French regulatory environment. A crisis-oriented lens guides the coding and interpretation of managerial AI use cases, enabling the identification of recurrent ethical dynamics (purpose drift, selective stakeholder visibility, algorithmic arbitration, and fragmented accountability). The resulting output is a conceptual framework that explains how AI-mediated executive sensemaking reorganizes stakeholder conflict and shapes whether resilience is enacted as short-term operational robustness or as longer-term ethical and institutional sustainability.

RESULTS: ETHICAL DYNAMICS OF MANAGERIAL AI UNDER MULTIPOLAR CRISIS CONDITIONS

The integrative analysis reveals four interrelated ethical dynamics through which managerial AI systems reshape organizational purpose, stakeholder relations, and resilience in healthcare organizations operating under multipolar crisis conditions. These dynamics are not discrete outcomes but mutually reinforcing processes that unfold through everyday managerial practices.

Purpose Drift Toward Operational Survival

The first dynamic concerns a gradual drift of organizational purpose toward short-term operational survival. Under sustained crisis conditions, healthcare organizations face intense pressure to maintain continuity of care despite resource constraints and uncertainty. Managerial AI systems are often mobilized to stabilize operations by optimizing patient flows, staffing levels, and resource utilization.

While such optimization can enhance immediate robustness, it also tends to privilege objectives that are quantifiable, immediate, and controllable. Over time, this emphasis can narrow organizational purpose to a set of operational performance indicators, marginalizing relational, ethical, and long-term considerations that are less easily captured by algorithms.

This drift is rarely explicit or intentional. Rather, it emerges through the cumulative effect of routine decisions justified by AI-generated outputs. As survival-oriented metrics become central to managerial attention, alternative interpretations of purpose such as commitments to equity, professional autonomy, or holistic care risk being reframed as secondary or aspirational. In this sense, managerial AI contributes to what may be described as *resilience drift*: the redefinition of resilience as operational endurance rather than ethical and institutional sustainability.

Selective Visibility and Reordering of Stakeholder Claims

The second dynamic relates to the selective visibility of stakeholders. Managerial AI systems render certain actors, activities, and outcomes more visible than others by virtue of how data are collected, processed, and displayed. Patients whose trajectories fit predictive models, units that generate standardized performance data, and activities aligned with reporting requirements tend to gain prominence in managerial decision-making.

Conversely, stakeholders whose needs are complex, qualitative, or temporally extended may become less visible. This includes patients with atypical care pathways, professionals engaged in relational or emotional labour, and communities affected by long-term access issues. Under crisis conditions, when decisions must be taken rapidly, this asymmetry of visibility becomes particularly consequential.

As a result, stakeholder conflict is not resolved but reconfigured. AI systems implicitly rank stakeholder claims by embedding them within optimization logics. These rankings often remain implicit, framed as technical necessities rather than ethical choices. Over time, this process reshapes organizational purpose by privileging certain interpretations of value creation and marginalizing others.

Algorithmic Arbitration of Moral Trade-Offs

A third dynamic concerns the normalization of algorithmic arbitration in contexts of moral pluralism. Healthcare management under crisis involves unavoidable trade-offs between competing values. Managerial AI systems increasingly intervene at precisely this point, translating complex ethical dilemmas into optimization problems.

For example, staffing algorithms may balance coverage requirements against cost constraints, while patient prioritization systems may weigh urgency against capacity. While such systems can support consistency, they also risk reframing moral dilemmas as technical problems with optimal solutions. This reframing can obscure the normative assumptions embedded in algorithmic models and reduce opportunities for ethical deliberation.

Under sustained crisis, reliance on algorithmic arbitration may become habitual. Managers may defer to AI-generated recommendations not because they are perceived as ethically superior, but because they provide defensible justifications in environments of heightened scrutiny and accountability. In this way, AI systems contribute to a depoliticization of ethical conflict, presenting contested choices as neutral outputs.

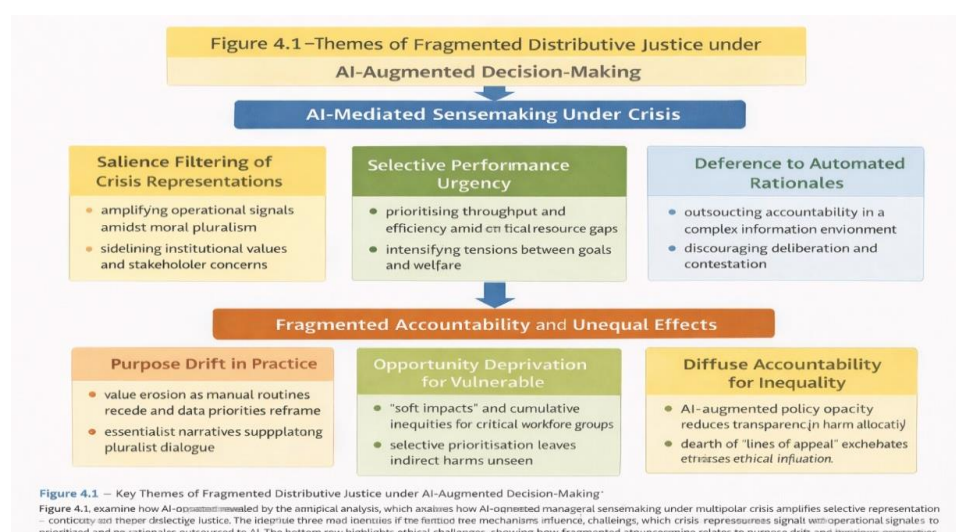
Fragmentation of Accountability in Crisis Governance

The fourth dynamic concerns the fragmentation of accountability. Managerial AI systems distribute decision-making across complex sociotechnical arrangements involving data scientists, IT departments, external vendors, managers, and executives. Under crisis conditions, this distribution can complicate responsibility attribution when decisions lead to adverse outcomes.

Because the effects of managerial AI are often indirect and cumulative, accountability gaps may persist without triggering formal incident responses. Decisions justified by algorithmic outputs can be perceived as collective or systemic, reducing individual accountability. This fragmentation risks undermining trust among stakeholders, particularly when negative outcomes disproportionately affect specific groups.

From the perspective of organizational purpose, fragmented accountability weakens the capacity of organizations to justify their actions ethically. Purpose statements lose credibility when stakeholders cannot identify who is responsible for decisions that affect them. Over time, this erosion of accountability undermines ethical and institutional resilience.

Figure 7: Ethical Dynamics of Managerial AI under Multipolar Crisis



Source: Author's own

Figure 7 summarizes the article's core conceptual findings by linking AI-mediated executive sensemaking to downstream ethical and distributive consequences under crisis conditions. The upper panel highlights how managerial AI filters crisis representations, amplifies performance urgency, and encourages deference to automated rationales thereby shaping what becomes salient, actionable, and defensible for decision-makers. The lower panel shows how these sensemaking effects translate into organizational dynamics: purpose drift toward short-term operational imperatives, cumulative opportunity deprivation for vulnerable groups, and diffuse accountability that weakens transparency and contestability. Taken together, the figure illustrates how managerial AI can enhance operational coordination while simultaneously reorganizing stakeholder conflict and placing ethical and institutional resilience at risk unless robust governance mechanisms are put in place.

DISCUSSION

This article set out to examine how the everyday use of artificial intelligence in healthcare management reshapes organizational purpose and resilience under conditions of multipolar crisis (Duchek, 2020; McGahan, 2023). The analysis highlights that managerial AI systems are not merely operational tools but active participants in executive sensemaking and stakeholder governance (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). This section discusses the theoretical implications of these findings for research on organizational purpose, crisis management, and ethical governance (Mota & Morrison, 2023; Mittelstadt, 2019).

Reframing Organizational Purpose Under Multipolar Crisis

The findings contribute to contemporary debates on organizational purpose by emphasizing its dynamic and contested nature under sustained crisis conditions (McGahan, 2023; Henisz, 2023). Rather than functioning as a stable guiding principle, organizational purpose emerges as an ongoing process of interpretation and justification, shaped by managerial practices and sociotechnical infrastructures (Mota & Morrison, 2023; Weick, 1995).

Managerial AI systems play a constitutive role in this process. By privileging certain forms of data, indicators, and predictive representations, AI systems influence how executives define what matters most in moments of organizational stress (Mittelstadt, 2019). This observation aligns with scholarship that conceptualizes purpose as embedded in organizational practices rather than solely articulated through formal statements (Mota & Morrison, 2023; McGahan, 2023). Under multipolar crisis conditions, purpose is enacted through routine decisions about resource allocation, prioritization, and risk management — decisions increasingly mediated by AI (WHO, 2021; OECD Legal Instruments, 2019).

Importantly, the analysis suggests that AI-mediated purpose is not inherently aligned with ethical or stakeholder-oriented objectives. Instead, it reflects the values and assumptions encoded within managerial optimization logics (Mittelstadt, 2019; Jobin et al., 2019). This insight challenges normative accounts that implicitly associate digital transformation with progressive or responsible organizational purposes, and underscores the need to examine how technologies reshape purpose in practice under constraint and urgency (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023).

Moral Pluralism, Stakeholder Conflict, and Algorithmic Governance

A central contribution of this article lies in its treatment of stakeholder conflict as a core ethical issue in managerial AI (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023). Consistent with theories of moral pluralism, the findings show that healthcare organizations face irreducible value conflicts that cannot be resolved through optimization alone (McGahan, 2023). Efficiency, equity, care quality, professional well-being, and public accountability represent competing yet legitimate claims (WHO, 2021).

Managerial AI systems intervene directly in this moral landscape by embedding particular hierarchies of value into decision-making processes (Mittelstadt, 2019). In doing so, they do not eliminate stakeholder conflict but reorganize it (Henisz, 2023). Algorithmic representations render some stakeholder claims visible and actionable while relegating others to the margins, often without explicit deliberation (Morley et al., 2020; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). This reordering is frequently framed as a technical necessity imposed by crisis conditions (Duchek, 2020).

This dynamic has important implications for stakeholder theory. It suggests that stakeholder governance increasingly operates through sociotechnical mechanisms rather than purely deliberative or relational processes (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023). AI systems become sites where stakeholder claims are translated, prioritized, or excluded (Mittelstadt, 2019). Understanding stakeholder governance in digitalized organizations therefore requires attention to the ethical politics of algorithmic mediation (Jobin et al., 2019).

Rethinking Organizational Resilience Beyond Operational Robustness

The findings also invite a critical reassessment of organizational resilience (Duchek, 2020). While managerial AI systems may enhance technical robustness by supporting continuity and coordination, they can simultaneously undermine ethical and institutional dimensions of resilience (Henisz, 2023).

Purpose drift toward short-term survival metrics, selective stakeholder visibility, and fragmented accountability all pose risks to long-term legitimacy and trust (McGahan, 2023; Morley et al., 2020). These challenges also illustrate that organizational resilience cannot be separated from wider environmental, social, regulatory, and technological conditions, all of which jointly shape the sustainability of organizational responses during prolonged crises (Malik, 2025).

This distinction between operational and ethical resilience is particularly salient in healthcare organizations, where legitimacy depends on public trust and moral credibility (WHO, 2021). Resilience achieved through the marginalization of vulnerable stakeholders or the erosion of professional autonomy may prove unsustainable over time (Morley et al., 2020; WHO, 2021). From this perspective, resilience should be understood not only as the capacity to endure shocks but as the ability to sustain organizational purpose under pressure (Duchek, 2020; McGahan, 2023).

Ethical governance of AI thus emerges as a resilience mechanism in its own right. By making value trade-offs explicit, preserving deliberative capacity, and maintaining accountability, ethical governance supports an organization's ability to navigate crises without compromising its foundational commitments (Mittelstadt, 2019; Henisz, 2023).

Executive Sensemaking and the Normalization of Algorithmic Authority

The analysis further contributes to research on executive sensemaking by highlighting the role of AI as a cognitive and interpretive infrastructure (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). In crisis contexts, executives face heightened uncertainty and scrutiny. AI-generated outputs offer seemingly objective representations that can stabilize decision-making and provide defensible justifications (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010; Mittelstadt, 2019).

However, this stabilization comes at a cost. The normalization of algorithmic authority may reduce reflexivity and suppress alternative interpretations of organizational reality (Weick, 1995). When AI outputs are treated as authoritative, executives may become less inclined to question underlying assumptions or to engage in ethical deliberation (Mittelstadt, 2019; Jobin et al., 2019). This dynamic risks narrowing the scope of sensemaking precisely when broader reflection is most needed (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010).

The findings therefore support calls for a more reflexive approach to digital leadership. Executive sensemaking in AI-mediated environments requires not only technical literacy but also ethical awareness and the capacity to interrogate algorithmic representations critically (Mittelstadt, 2019; WHO, 2021).

Ethical Governance as a Condition for Legitimate Crisis Management

Taken together, the findings suggest that ethical governance of managerial AI is not an auxiliary concern but a central condition for legitimate crisis management (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023). In multipolar crises, organizations are judged not only on outcomes but also on how decisions are made and justified (Duchek, 2020). AI systems that obscure responsibility, depoliticize ethical trade-offs, or marginalize stakeholder voices risk undermining organizational legitimacy (Mittelstadt, 2019; Morley et al., 2020).

By contrast, governance arrangements that foreground purpose, accountability, and deliberation can enhance ethical resilience (Henisz, 2023). Such arrangements enable organizations to absorb shocks while maintaining trust and coherence in their stakeholder relationships (Duchek, 2020; WHO, 2021).

This perspective shifts the focus of AI ethics from isolated design principles to organizational capacities for ethical sensemaking under pressure (Mittelstadt, 2019; Jobin et al., 2019).

MANAGERIAL AND METHODOLOGICAL IMPLICATIONS

Methodological Implications for Research on AI, Crisis, and Organizational Purpose

This article offers several methodological implications for future research at the intersection of artificial intelligence, organizational purpose, and crisis management (McGahan, 2023; Duchek, 2020).

Firstly, it underscores the importance of studying AI as a situated organizational practice rather than as an isolated technological artefact (Mittelstadt, 2019; Morley et al., 2020). Much of the existing literature evaluates AI systems in terms of performance, accuracy, or compliance with ethical principles (Jobin et al., 2019). While valuable, such approaches risk overlooking how AI becomes embedded in everyday managerial routines and how its ethical effects accumulate over time (Morley et al., 2020). Process-oriented and qualitative methodologies — such as ethnographies of decision-making, shadowing of managerial work, and in-depth case studies — are particularly well suited to capturing these dynamics (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010; Weick, 1995).

Secondly, the findings highlight the need for crisis-sensitive research designs. Rather than treating crises as exceptional episodes, scholars should conceptualize them as a structural condition that shapes organizational sensemaking, priorities, and governance arrangements (Duchek, 2020). Longitudinal studies that examine AI use before, during, and after crisis phases can illuminate how organizational purpose evolves under sustained pressure and how ethical compromises become normalized or resisted (McGahan, 2023; Henisz, 2023).

Thirdly, the article points to the value of stakeholder-centred analytical frameworks. Future research should examine how different stakeholder groups experience AI-mediated management, particularly those whose voices are less visible in formal decision-making processes (Henisz, 2023; Morley et al., 2020). Combining organizational analysis with stakeholder perspectives can help reveal the distributive and relational effects of managerial AI that remain invisible in aggregate performance metrics (WHO, 2021).

Finally, this study invites further comparative research across institutional and national contexts. While grounded in the European and French regulatory environment, the conceptual framework developed here is intended to be analytically transferable (OECD Legal Documents, 2019; WHO, 2021). Comparative studies could explore how different governance regimes, cultural norms, and crisis trajectories shape the ethical implications of managerial AI and the enactment of organizational purpose (Duchek, 2020; McGahan, 2023).

Managerial Implications: Ethical Governance as Organizational Resilience

For practitioners, the findings carry important implications for leadership and governance in healthcare organizations operating under multipolar crisis conditions (Duchek, 2020; WHO, 2021).

Firstly, managers and executives should recognize that AI systems actively shape organizational purpose (McGahan, 2023; Mota & Morrison, 2023). Decisions about which AI tools to adopt, how they are configured, and how their outputs are interpreted are not merely technical choices but normative ones (Mittelstadt, 2019; Jobin et al., 2019). Explicitly articulating organizational purpose under crisis — and clarifying which values must not be sacrificed in the pursuit of operational stability — can help counteract unintended purpose drift (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023).

Secondly, organizations should treat ethical AI governance as a core resilience capability. Rather than viewing ethics as a constraint on efficiency, leaders should understand ethical governance as a mechanism that sustains legitimacy, trust, and stakeholder commitment over time (Henisz, 2023). This broader perspective is consistent with evidence that organizational resilience during crises increasingly depends upon stakeholder trust, sustainability orientation, and well-being rather than operational efficiency alone (Chan et al., 2022). This involves preserving spaces for deliberation, ensuring that AI-mediated decisions remain contestable, and maintaining clear lines of accountability even under pressure (Mittelstadt, 2019; Morley et al., 2020).

Thirdly, executive teams should invest in reflexive sensemaking practices. This includes developing the capacity to question AI-generated representations, to surface underlying assumptions, and to consider alternative interpretations of organizational reality (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). Training programs for leaders should therefore integrate ethical reflection and critical data literacy alongside technical competencies (WHO, 2021; OECD Legal Documents, 2019).

Fourthly, healthcare organizations should adopt stakeholder-sensitive monitoring practices. Organizations should pay attention to signals of ethical strain beyond traditional performance indicators - such as rising staff turnover, patient dissatisfaction in marginalized groups, or recurrent justifications of difficult decisions solely on technical grounds (Morley et al., 2020; Henisz, 2023). These signals can serve as early warnings of eroding ethical resilience (Duchek, 2020).

CONCLUSION

This article examined how the everyday use of artificial intelligence in healthcare management reshapes organizational purpose, stakeholder governance, and resilience under conditions of multipolar crisis (Duchek, 2020; McGahan, 2023). Moving beyond instrumental accounts of AI as a tool for efficiency and coordination, the analysis conceptualizes managerial AI as a sensemaking infrastructure that mediates executive interpretation, moral trade-offs, and accountability (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010).

The findings demonstrate that managerial AI systems do not resolve stakeholder conflict but reorganize it (Henisz, 2023; McGahan, 2023). By privileging certain forms of visibility, normalizing algorithmic arbitration, and fragmenting accountability, AI systems contribute to a redefinition of organizational purpose that may enhance short-term operational robustness while undermining ethical and institutional resilience (Mittelstadt, 2019; Morley et al., 2020). These dynamics are particularly salient in healthcare organizations, where legitimacy depends on sustained trust and moral credibility (WHO, 2021).

By reframing AI ethics as a question of organizational purpose and resilience, this article contributes to debates on executive sensemaking, stakeholder governance, and responsible leadership in times of sustained crisis (Mota & Morrison, 2023; McGahan, 2023). It calls for a shift from principle-based ethics toward organizational capacities for ethical governance, capable of sustaining deliberation, accountability, and purpose under pressure (Mittelstadt, 2019; Jobin et al., 2019).

Ultimately, the article argues that the ethical governance of managerial AI is not a peripheral concern but a defining challenge for organizations seeking to remain legitimate and resilient in an era of continuous crisis (Duchek, 2020; Henisz, 2023).

Note: All research was conducted in accordance with the accepted ethical guidelines.

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